Canary in coal mine

Core sector data indicate impending growth slowdowns

The latest data on the performance of the core industrial sectors show the economy may be facing an industrial uptick, but questions about its sustainability remain. Growth in the Index of Core Industries rose to a series-high of 7.9% in September 2026, the second consecutive month of accelerated performance. Any such improvement is to be celebrated, but a deeper look at what is driving it is also warranted. The coal sector saw growth suddenly shoot up to 10.7% in September. The unexpected and unusual nature of this rapid acceleration can be borne out by the fact that the sector contracted by 1.1% over the longer April-September 2026 period. The growth in coal in September was likely a temporary blip aided by a statistical low base and, more importantly, pressure from power plant operators over rapidly depleting coal stocks amid the heat wave. The electricity sector grew 11.4% in September, capping off a half-year dominated by double-digit growth. This surge in electricity-related demand for coal will likely wane, especially since the El Niño factor that drove the heat wave will also result in a milder winter. The other sector that results in high coal usage, the steel sector, did accelerate in September, but not by enough to sustain the coal sector's September output. The uptick in steel did, however, result in a return to double-digit growth for the iron ore sector, which should bode well for the mining component of the larger Index of Industrial Production.

The performance of the crude oil, natural gas, and refinery products sectors also highlights the fiscal problems India faces. At a time when the crude oil and natural gas sectors have both contracted continuously since 2024, refinery output rose to 10.3% in September. This means that the refineries were increasingly processing expensive imported oil. India's oil imports in September were up 7% by volume but jumped 47% in terms of value due to the high price of oil. This is set to worsen. The attacks on Saudi Arabia's energy infrastructure have already pushed global oil prices above $112 a barrel, almost a six-month high. The reprieve from the U.S. on potential tariffs linked to imports of Russian oil provide India a reliable source, but the days of discounts are long gone. It is the time of premium pricing, and each barrel imported is eating into India's foreign exchange reserves, which are also being used to defend the rupee. Cement and steel are the only sustainably growing core sectors, and those too are based on government infrastructure spending. At a time when industrial output is only temporarily propped up, the government's fiscal space is fast shrinking.

Tunnelling through

Domestic manufacturing and foreign partnerships must go hand-in-hand

The Chinese Ministry of Commerce and the General Administration of Customs decision to place tunnel-boring machines (TBMs) on an export control list reveals a blind spot in India's supply chain diversification. The curbs include TBMs, walking excavators, and high-altitude wet shotcrete machines. From November 18, if a shipment is intended for countries or regions deemed sensitive due to ongoing disputes with China, exporters will need an export licence from commerce authorities. For other countries/regions, exporters will need to be registered, obtain an export certificate, and submit end-use declarations stating that the equipment will not be re-routed to sensitive locations. While China has cornered around 70% of the global TBM market, prominent manufacturers in the West also maintain substantial component supply chains in the country to cut manufacturing overhead. Further, TBMs are complex to build as they have to be configured to geological characteristics at the project site and perform numerous tasks. Where a suitable TBM exists, it can be used for civilian or military purposes. India has struggled with TBM-related hold-ups with China for at least two years now, including for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail project. Germany's Herrenknecht AG set up an assembling and refurbishing facility in Chennai in 2007-08. TBM production economics differ significantly from conventional construction equipment as new plants need a minimum number of orders and must be able to access the industrial capability required to design, manufacture and repair specialised components.

However, even though India is one of the world's largest TBM importers, expecting every sophisticated machine to be produced domestically will send public infrastructure costs soaring. Even now, depending on China's decision on the TBMs set for India, India may have to redirect its procurement to facilities based directly in Germany or Japan, say, and absorb the higher capital cost. The BEML experience shows that manufacturing partnerships can fail without secure licensing arrangements and access to sustained demand. India should pursue domestic manufacturing alongside international partnerships, e.g., making equipment in the country under agreement with established foreign firms, and develop shared industrial capabilities rather than singular 'national champions', as TBM manufacturers and their suppliers can benefit from access to common testing and precision manufacturing infrastructure. Overall, Beijing is systematically identifying sectors where it commands a significant global capacity and establishing export controls to counter western technological restrictions, such as on advanced semiconductors, so any critical infrastructure sector relying on Chinese supply lines will face a compounding geopolitical risk.

Prasar Bharati is not a public service broadcaster

Suhas Borker

Editor, Citizens First TV (CFTV), who has advocated public service broadcasting since the 1990s as convener of Jan Prasar. In 2000, he conceptualised National Public Service Broadcasting Day, on November 12

When the Narendra Modi government took office in May 2014, the then Information and Broadcasting Minister, Prakash Javadekar, promised to end the "government fiefdom" over Prasar Bharati and recast it on the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) model: autonomous in administration, free in editorial judgement, and accountable to Parliament.

Twelve years later that promise remains unfulfilled. The 138th episode of "Mann Ki Baat", broadcast on September 27, 2026, is only the most visible reminder that the state still treats the public airwaves as its own platform.

The BBC model, unfulfilled

The irony is sharp. The same political class that invoked the BBC as the template, later accused it of a "continuing colonial mindset" after it telecast the documentary in 2023, "India: The Modi Question". From April 2024 the BBC had to split its Indian news operation to meet foreign-investment rules.

The deeper story is older than the Emergency. In 1948, Jawaharlal Nehru told the Constituent Assembly – then the only authoritative Indian statement on the British model – "my own view of the set-up for broadcasting is that we should approximate, as far as possible, to the British model, the BBC, that is to say, it would be better if we had a semi-autonomous corporation under the government, of course with the policy controlled by the government, otherwise not conducted as a government department." Even that caveat – "otherwise not conducted as a government department" – has not been honoured.

Mark Tully, former BBC bureau chief in Delhi, put the same distinction succinctly in a conversation in 2017: public service broadcasting "is not the same as government broadcast". It rests on two principles, he said – that the government must not interfere in the broadcaster's autonomy, and that programmes must not be judged by commercial merit alone. Without autonomy and freedom, he added, All India Radio cannot become a broadcaster for transformative change.

The Emergency of 1975 reduced All India Radio (AIR) and Doordarshan to instruments of the regime. After Indira Gandhi's defeat, the Janata government asked B.G. Verghese to recommend autonomy. His BBC-style model became a Bill in 1979 (Prasar Bharati Bill), but the Bill lapsed. A new version, introduced in 1989 as "a charter of freedom" under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution, received assent in 1990 – as the Prasar Bharati (Broadcasting Corporation of India) Act, 1990 – and was enforced only in 1997. Its Statement of Objects and Reasons said the corporation should be "a genuinely autonomous body – innovative, dynamic and flexible – with a high degree of credibility", responsible to the people and to Parliament. Nearly three decades on, Prasar Bharati is not that body. It is a pretender, a mouthpiece of the government of the day. Section 12 of the Act is the editorial constitution that was meant to lock that intent in. The primary duty is to organise public broadcasting services to inform, educate and entertain. Section 12(2)(b) requires the corporation to safeguard "the citizen's right to be informed freely, truthfully and objectively" and to present "a fair and balanced flow of information including contrasting views without advocating any opinion or ideology of its own".

Prasar Bharati remains a pretender — 12 years after a promise of BBC-style autonomy, the corporation is still on a ministerial leash

At the Ministry's mercy

A truncated corporation was set up so that it cannot function independently of government. Critical Sections 13, 14 and 15 of the Act remain unimplemented. Section 13 requires a 22-member parliamentary committee, elected from both Houses, to oversee Prasar Bharati on Parliament's behalf. No government has constituted it. Former chief executive Jawhar Sircar has explained why: Ministers insist that they alone are answerable to Parliament and therefore retain the power to summon AIR and Doordarshan officials until they succumb.

Sections 14 and 15 require a Broadcasting Council to receive complaints and guard political impartiality. That Council has never been set up, and it follows that there is no system for editorial redress. The Board, meant to be professionally managed, has been filled with pliable bureaucrats. Ownership of assets and staff was never transferred. Without its own fund, the Board remains at the Ministry's mercy. Section 23 still lets the Centre issue binding directions on what may or may not be broadcast.

Section 10 required a recruitment board to keep appointments free of government interference. Nothing happened until July 2020, when Jagadish Upasane, who headed Bharat Prakashan, publisher of Panchajanya and Organiser, was made chairman. Autonomy was compromised the moment it was announced. A 2021 manpower audit used the BBC as the benchmark: almost half of Prasar Bharati's then 25,000-strong workforce sat in engineering, against a little over 10% at the BBC, while content staff were under 20% against about 70%. The numbers described a transmission machine, not a Content-and-News-driven broadcaster.

UNESCO's 2001 definition is exacting. Public broadcasting is neither commercial nor state-controlled; it speaks to every citizen. Prasar Bharati fails that test. In 2000 the government declared November 12 as Public Service Broadcasting Day to mark Gandhiji's only AIR broadcast, made in 1947 to two lakh refugees at Kurukshetra. The day has since become tokenism. In 2022 even that tokenism turned into farce when a Christian hymn sung by school students was sought to be dropped from the commemorative national broadcast.

The social contract is simple. The broadcaster has the right to speak freely, and in return it owes the public accuracy, impartiality, and independence from both the market and the Ministry. Nehru's 1948 formula already drew that line: policy may be set, the daily conduct of broadcasting may not be run as a government department. In 1995, Justice P.B. Sawant, speaking for the Supreme Court in *Secretary, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting vs Cricket Association of Bengal*, went further. Airwaves are public property, he held, and the Centre must establish an independent autonomous public authority to control their use. Public broadcasting is not state broadcasting. That direction has still not been carried out.

There must be political will

What needs to be done is already known. The parliamentary committee must be constituted, the Board rebuilt as a professional body, and assets and staff transferred. The regulatory council named in the Act must be created, funding designed without government strings, and Indian Information Service officers removed from operational control. The 1990 Act must be amended where practice has exposed its traps.

None of this happens without political will. The syndrome is familiar: autonomy is criticised out of power and forgotten in power. In August 2026, the government told the Lok Sabha that it had received no formal complaints from journalists or media bodies about its autonomy in the previous year. The absence of filed grievances is not evidence of independence. The Broadcasting Council named in the Act was never created, so there is nowhere for such a complaint to go.

The Chanda Committee, appointed when Indira Gandhi was Information and Broadcasting Minister, concluded in 1966 that "a psychological transformation is necessary" in the government's approach to broadcasting. Sixty years later that transformation has not come, and Nehru's "otherwise not conducted as a government department" remains unkept words. The options before the people are two: approach the courts to enforce the Act and the Sawant direction, or wait for the 2029 general election and a Lok Sabha willing to turn Prasar Bharati from a government handmaiden into a public service broadcaster. Until then it remains what it has been for nearly three decades: a disguised pretender.

Tied by geography, divided by politics



Mohammed Ayoob

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With speculation rife that Bangladesh's recently elected Prime Minister Tarique Rahman (and also Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) Chairman) will be visiting New Delhi in November or December, it is time to assess the state of India-Bangladesh relations and analyse the roots of the problems between the two countries.

The seeds of their current tension lie in the liberation war of 1971 itself. From the very beginning, the attitude of Bangladesh's elites toward India has wavered between gratitude and resentment – gratitude for India's crucial role in the liberation of their country and resentment against the fact that India had to play the role of liberator – a role they should have performed themselves.

An ambivalence

Nations cherish narratives in which they are the principal authors of their own liberation. Bangladesh is no exception. The contribution of the Mukti Bahini notwithstanding, the decisive military blow against Pakistan was delivered by India. What was initially the source of immense gratitude with the passage of time became a source of grave discomfort.

Moreover, from the very beginning Dhaka was worried that India's policy towards Bangladesh would be mediated through a Hindu-majority West Bengal next door which has strong cultural and linguistic affinities with Bangladesh that could threaten the development of Bangladesh's independent identity. The open borders in the immediate aftermath of the liberation war also revived memories of the socio-economic dominance of the Hindu bhadralok in pre-Partition Bengal.

This was compounded by the fact that Bangladesh was virtually surrounded by India, sharing a border of more than 4,000 kilometres. Its principal rivers flowed through or originated in India. Its economic and strategic room for manoeuvre appeared constrained by geography. Consequently, the fear of Indian domination became an important component of Bangladeshi nationalism.

India and Bangladesh must overcome mistrust and pursue pragmatic neighbourhood cooperation

The honeymoon between Dhaka and New Delhi was indeed short. Sheikh Mujib and Indira Gandhi shared a great deal of goodwill. But the governments that succeeded Mujib deliberately distanced Bangladesh from India. Under Ziaur Rahman, Bangladeshi nationalism was redefined in overtly Islamic terms in contradistinction to the linguistic nationalism that had provided the ideological foundation of the liberation movement.

Dhaka's foreign policy

This had important foreign policy consequences. Dhaka sought closer relations with Pakistan, China, and the United States to counterbalance India. What New Delhi often interpreted as gratuitous anti-Indianism was, from Dhaka's perspective, an assertion of strategic autonomy by a much weaker state living in the shadow of an overwhelmingly powerful neighbour.

This pattern became deeply embedded in Bangladesh's domestic politics. The Awami League remained identified with the secular and Bengali-nationalist legacy of 1971 and generally favoured close relations with India. The BNP and its allies were much more suspicious of New Delhi. India consequently ceased to be merely a foreign policy issue; attitudes towards India became part of the contest over Bangladesh's national identity.

But this success contained the seeds of the subsequent backlash. India increasingly identified its interests not merely with Bangladesh but with Sheikh Hasina and the Awami League. As criticism mounted within Bangladesh over the increasingly authoritarian character of her government, New Delhi was widely perceived as placing its own security interests above Bangladesh's democratic evolution.

Ms. Hasina's overthrow in August 2024 therefore produced not merely a change of government but a profound crisis for Indian policy. Her flight to India reinforced suspicions that New Delhi was the external pillar of the political order just overthrown. India's continuing refusal to extradite her has ensured that the Hasina question remains a major bilateral irritant.

The road ahead

The election of Mr. Rahman and the return of the BNP to power in February 2026 have opened a new chapter. Both New Delhi and Dhaka have compelling reasons to avoid permanent alienation, and functional engagement has resumed. But substantial mutual suspicion continues to bedevil bilateral relations.

The lesson that New Delhi should draw from the turbulent history of the relationship is that India cannot expect gratitude for 1971 to constitute the permanent foundation of Bangladeshi foreign policy. Gratitude is a transient sentiment; national interest especially when linked to issues of national identity is enduring.

Indeed, repeatedly invoking India's role in Bangladesh's liberation can be counterproductive because it reinforces precisely the Bangladeshi psychological trauma that has troubled the relationship from its inception.

Dhaka, for its part, cannot wish away geography. No relationship with Beijing, Islamabad or Washington can substitute for a workable relationship with the country that surrounds Bangladesh on three sides, shares its major river systems and is indispensable to its regional connectivity.

India must learn to exercise its preponderant power with restraint and sensitivity and abjure demanding reciprocity for any magnanimity it shows towards its smaller neighbour especially on the sharing of river waters. Bangladesh must recognise that strategic autonomy need not be defined through knee-jerk opposition to India. Only then can the two countries finally move beyond the burdens of the past while preserving its most important legacy: the recognition that their security and stability are inextricably intertwined.